FEELING LOST IN I.N.D.I.A.

The implosion in the Opposition alliance has turned into some cynicism among voters but they are also unhappy at the ruling BJP's bid to browbeat rivals

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When leaders of more than two dozen Opposition parties met in Bengaluru on July 17-18 last year to discuss the structure and narrative of a national alliance, the bonhomie between two leaders caught everyone's attention. If the Congress party came up with the politically sharp acronym I.N.D.I.A. (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance), its leader Rahul Gandhi insisted that West Bengal chief minister and Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee propose the name at the meeting. In response, she called Rahul "our favourite", a sharp departure from her veiled criticism of his leadership in the past.

Cut to February 2024 and the "favourite" has turned into everyone's dart board. After announcing that her party will contest the Lok Sabha polls on its own without any seat-sharing agreement with the Congress and Left parties, Mamata launched a no-holds-barred attack on Rahul. She challenged the Congress to take on the BJP in the Hindi heartland states and expressed doubt in its ability to secure "even 40 seats" in the coming Lok Sabha election. Then she took pot shots at Rahul's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra, which traversed through six districts of Bengal, calling it a "photo opportunity" for "migratory birds".

Her onslaught came just five days after another I.N.D.I.A. partner, Nitish Kumar of the Janata Dal (United), in neighbouring Bihar, switched to the BJP-led NDA to take oath as the chief minister for the ninth time. For the record, Nitish was the architect behind the formation of I.N.D.I.A. He had not only convinced parties wary of ceding space to the Congress to join hands with it, but also convened the first meeting of the group at his Circular Road residence in Patna on June 23 last year. His departure is a body blow to the primary narrative of Opposition unity against the alleged misrule of the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led BJP government at the Centre. Like Mamata, Nitish also blamed the Congress, particularly Rahul, for the lack of trust in I.N.D.I.A. While the national party was expected to play pivot, it became the pain point within the group, allegedly showing no urgency over seat-sharing discussions and even demanding a disproportionate number of seats from allies.